

Episode 181: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 8

The other day I completely moved out all the remaining equipment and luggage from the Mitaka studio. There's still some *Mawaru Penguindrum* leftover business to handle here and there, but the staff room where I was is already in the thick of work on a different title (apparently an April new series). So I withdrew to avoid being in the way.

The seat after cleaning up your own equipment is somehow lonely. Exactly one year since the Great East Japan Earthquake. As I wrote here before, exactly one year ago I encountered that major earthquake in Mitaka. Various memories from that time, memories of working hard for a year after that, and the final rush days - all sorts of things pass through my heart.

Will there come a day when I can work here again? Producer Tokiwa said this to me at the end:

"Next time I do a 'stylish' work, I'll definitely have Tsujita-san come!"

Thank you, Tokiwa-san, I'm happy. But somehow it seems that in Tokiwa-san's mind I've become the person who does "stylish" works and "celebrity" works... Hmm? Huh? Was this *Mawaru Penguindrum* a stylish work? That part is a mystery (laugh).

Episode 6: You and I Connected by M Storyboard & Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

The three members of the "Takakura Kanba Victims Association" - hospitalised Kuho Asami doesn't remember Kanba at all, and the remaining two also have their memories erased after being shot by someone with mysterious red balls. Meanwhile, Ringo has Shoma help her create a love nest under the floor of Tabuki's apartment, scheming for a "first night" with Tabuki. In this episode, the relationship between Ringo's sister Momoka (桃果) and the "fate diary," and between Tabuki and Ringo, begins to be

revealed, and the reason why Ringo's family collapsed is also clarified. Mysteries are gradually revealed, and even more mysteries increase. Such was Episode 6.

"Before going to see a play with Tabuki, isn't there some good place near Higashi-Koenji Station?" I was consulted by Director Yamazaki before starting storyboard work. For me, born and raised in Nakano, this Higashi-Koenji area at the border between Nakano and Suginami was an area where I had some familiarity, since friends lived there during high school. So I went location hunting with a camera to find places. This was in December 2010. Oh, Higashi-Koenji is where Ringo's apartment is located. So after visiting Ringo's house, if Tabuki and Ringo were to talk, it would be near this station, we decided. Incidentally, the entrance to Wadazuka Park that appeared in Episode 4 was modelled on "Sanshi no Mori Park" located along Ome Kaido, very close to Higashi-Koenji Station.

So I went location hunting alone by bicycle. I took photos of various things - small shrines, promising-looking back alleys, and such - but among them, what struck Director Yamazaki's heartstrings was that "frog park." She seemed to like those mysterious frog ornaments lined up on the benches (laugh). Several cuts in the main story use layouts exactly matching the reference photos I took. Also, while black cats appeared in the main story, there were actually cats when I went too (laugh). Also, the road where Ringo and Tabuki walk with numerous drainage pipes protruding from the wall is an actual road beside an elementary school playground or such.

Also, the department store rooftop where the two girls called by Kanba are sniped with "red balls" is based on the rooftop of Town Seven at Ogikubo Station's north exit. Even that yellow object of indeterminate shape (actually children's playground equipment) is exactly as it was. Like Sunshine Aquarium in Ikebukuro, *Mawaru Penguindrum* secretly and casually uses real places as source material in this way throughout.

So, the "red balls" used in this rooftop sniping and in Asami's hospital room - they're red from being fired until impact, grey after impact when they "shubabaabababa" and suck something out, and finally become pure white ash. The KIGA mark on the red balls is material pasted in during photography (in later episodes the balls become 3DCG entirely), but from the ash stage it's pencil drawing with a burnt touch. Initially when the

animation came up, I rejected it, and Yamazaki redrew the animation to match the setting. This felt quite good. So we used this completed main story "burnt material" as paste-in material for later episodes.

Even so, this gun has laser sighting but what it fires is a manual pachinko (wry laugh).

Episode 6, while appearing comedic on the surface, actually contains quite serious scenes and suspenseful scenes, with conversations that are keys to future stories woven throughout. In terms of colour design, I deliberately used the most realistic colour usage up to this point in the series. For the evening scene at Ringo's apartment, I carefully built up the subtlety of evening sunlight interfering with shadows. Also, in hospital room scenes and rooftop scenes, I created deep shadows to match the tense direction, and applied gradations to shadow boundary lines to explore suspicious atmospheres. I wanted to properly create a gap and contrast with the comedic touch direction.

Also, in the flashback scene between Ringo and Tabuki at the frog park, while the background was made into an evening scene with pink~purple imagery, I made the characters with slightly stronger purple tones than the background. Since this was the scene where Ringo and Tabuki first spoke about Momoka, it was reality but with Ringo's memory images coming through strongly - I thought such a meaningful screen would be good.

Oh yes, just before this frog park scene there's a scene with Ringo, Tabuki, and Ringo's mother at the dinner table, but this is a scene that also appeared in Episode 3. However, in the actual broadcast, Ringo's clothes are different in Episodes 3 and 6. Actually, this scene was originally supposed to have all three wearing black formal wear. But I think during Episode 3's production, the story's temporal setting was changed, and high school student Tabuki would wear his uniform instead of formal wear. Ringo also wore a black dress with black stockings. Her mother also wore black.

Actually, I should have corrected Ringo during Episode 3, but I thought, well, maybe it's okay? The Episode 6 script was already up during Episode 3, so I should have noticed,

but when Episode 6's storyboard came up and I faced that scene, "Ah! (sweat)." So I secretly corrected it in Episode 6. I corrected Ringo's clothes to match what she wore in the subsequent frog park scene. Incidentally, after that I was planning to secretly replace Episode 3 for Blu-ray & DVD... ah, sorry, I forgot! (apologetic (sweat))

Making screens like the frog park while simultaneously making screens more gag-like for scenes with important, serious content is actually one of this work's patterns. So in this episode, the scene of Ringo's flashback of her parents fighting (Kappa and Otter) is made extremely surreal and gag-like. The content being told is quite an important flashback explaining Ringo's situation. During the stage of creating setting colours for this scene, we talked about "if things escalated, they'd normally throw something, right?" "The father (Otter) could throw shells, but the mother (Kappa) has nothing... Ah! The plate! (explosion)" - so it became a performance where she removes the plate from her head and throws it (laugh).

The pink colour tone of the final "first night in progress" scene under the floor of Tabuki's apartment was created imagining a somewhat seedy Showa-era love hotel (laugh). I requested this during the art board meeting. Ah, this might be why *Mawaru Penguindrum* gets called a "Showa anime" in some quarters (laugh).

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